

Abounding in the Work of the Lord

by Keiran Bastiaan McMorrow

Call me Theodore. A few years ago, I worked as a professor at the Brooks Institute of Social Science in New York City. My qualifications were amongst the highest in the Institute, and I was proud of that fact.

One afternoon in July of 1891, I sat at my desk fanning myself while flipping through a book on economics. The heat was irritating, but I could do little, as the ceiling fan had broken and the faculty storage room had no replacement parts. At last, I put the book down and opened the window, should any draft wander in. I had just turned around when a knock startled me.

“Come in,” I said.

“Ah, Mr. Hayes, I’ve been looking for you.”

At the door stood a bearded man in his late 50s, wearing round spectacles and dressed rather warmly despite the summer heat.

“Oh, Mr. Brooks, do come in and have a seat,” I said.

Arthur Brooks, Headmaster of the Brooks Institute of Social Science, was a close friend and mentor of mine. He took off his coat and sat by the window.

“Listen, Theo, I have some news,” he said.

“What is it?” I asked.

“You are aware of the Institute’s missionary efforts out in the countryside?”

“Yes.”

“Then you know of Mr. Bennett and the school he started.”

“I remember it well.”

Arthur leaned forward. “Mr. Bennett has decided to leave the school and serve as a missionary in East Asia.”

I looked at Arthur, knowing he had more to say. "Then we must wish him well and write to him at once," I said.

"Mr. Bennett has asked that you serve in his stead as headmaster of his school," Arthur said.

I stared at him.

"Oh, don't give me that look, Theo. You always said you wanted to live in the countryside," he said.

"Yes, when I retire! Not when I am in my prime in the best university in the country!" I protested.

"Think about it. You're still young and strong," Arthur said.

"But Mr. Brooks, surely you know I am more than overqualified to teach children basic reading and writing."

The idea seemed preposterous. It felt a waste that I should teach a school with at most thirty children, who likely could not do basic arithmetic.

"I'll give you time to pray and think about it, Theo," said Arthur. He rose, took his coat, and left.

That night I sat on my bed and thought. Arthur was right; I was still young enough that labour in the countryside would not harm me. Yet the question remained. Why me? Of all the people in the Institute, surely Mr. Bennett could have chosen someone else. I knelt beside my bed and prayed.

"Dear Heavenly Father, I come to You with a request for guidance. Mr. Bennett has requested me to succeed him in teaching the children at the school he started. Mr. Brooks has told me that I would be a great choice, but I am not sure. Surely anyone else could have been chosen."

In the middle of my prayer, a thought came to me. Perhaps Mr. Bennett chose me because of my qualifications. Perhaps he trusted me to teach these children. "If it is Your wish, then I will teach these children to the best of my abilities," I said.

I do not know why I said it so readily. Perhaps I was in the moment. I finished my prayer and fell asleep shortly after. I awoke early the next morning, made a simple meal, dressed, and headed to the headmaster's office. Arthur looked up as I entered.

"A fine morning to you, Mr. Hayes," he said.

"Good morning to you too, Mr. Brooks. I have decided the Lord wants me to teach Mr. Bennett's school," I said.

Arthur smiled. "Wonderful, Mr. Hayes. I knew you would come around."

"If it is God's wish, then I will teach these children to the best of my abilities," I replied.

A few days later I took a train to the town where the school was. I packed light and spent much of the ride trying to picture what it would be like to teach there. When the train slowed and the conductor announced my stop, I stepped off into the station. Then it struck me that I did not know how to get to the school.

"Need a ride, sir?" a voice said. I turned around. Before me was a stocky man with a thick dark mustache.

"Well, sir, you don't look like you're from around here. I figured I could give you a ride into town. The name's Almanzo," said the man.

"I'm Theodore Hayes," I replied. "If you would, I'd be very grateful." He led me to his wagon and climbed aboard. I followed, dragging my briefcase.

"So, Hayes, what brings you 'round here?" Almanzo asked as we made our way into town.

"I'm here to take over as schoolteacher for Mr. Lewis Bennett. He has gone to pursue missionary work in the Far East," I told him.

“Well I’ll be, it is you!” Almanzo exclaimed. “Mr. Bennett spoke highly of you. If he says you’re the man for the job, I’d believe him.”

“That is very kind of him. I’ll do my best,” I said.

Soon we were on Main Street. Almanzo dropped me off in front of the General Store and gave me directions to the school. I made my way there, observing my surroundings as I went. The streets were dirt and mud, unlike the cobblestone back in the city. At last I saw the school in the distance. It was a house of wood painted white. I stepped inside. The room was a single classroom with benches and desks on either side of a middle aisle. I walked to the teacher’s desk, set down my briefcase, and sat with an exhausted sigh.

The next morning, I had breakfast, got dressed, and began setting up the classroom. One by one the students came in, whispering amongst themselves, most undoubtedly about me. I introduced myself and the day went on without much fanfare, though class was interrupted often by the children wanting to know more about me.

About a week in, I could safely say that children were much more difficult to handle than the more refined young men and women at the Institute. Slowly but surely, I disciplined those rowdy children. Every Sunday, I saw them at church, and afterward I spoke with the parents. A few children stood out to me. One boy named Thomas had aspirations of becoming a doctor because of his mother’s illness.

“I want to be a doctor to help my Ma, Mr. Hayes,” he would say.

“But Ma and Pa said that I would need to go to a big school back east,” said Thomas.

I knew how much this meant to him, and in time he proved himself an excellent student. I sent a letter of commendation to Arthur, and soon Thomas was accepted and went off to become a doctor.

There was also Stephen. He had no hopes of attending college, and would slack off in the back row during classes. I gave him a firm but understanding talking to. Stephen simply nodded

and shrugged his shoulders. I stayed after school to help him with his arithmetic and spelling, and slowly he began to improve. His grades rose, and in time he secured work with his uncle in another town.

At the end of my first year, the students and I organised a feast and invited their parents. It was a grand old time, and I told the parents I was proud of their children's progress. Eventually most of the students I had taught moved on in life, either to find work or seek higher education. I wished them all well. Slowly the rest were replaced by new ones, and I began to teach them as I had taught the others.

And that is where the story ends for now. I sit at my desk in the same classroom I wrote about. The hour is late and I must soon retire to bed. I thank God for the opportunity to teach these children, and I still write to Arthur regularly, giving him updates on my students' progress.

To all of you reading my memoir, I leave this final message: if it is God's wish, do whatever He requests to the best of your abilities, no matter the strife and hardship.

"Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye steadfast, unmoveable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord"

I Corinthians 15:58

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